

What are we strangers to?

For we are strangers on the earth, as were all our fathers; keep our short life without sin, O our Savior, and have mercy on us, as the lover of mankind.

The Troparion of the Prophecy, 1st Tone: Clean Tuesday, the 6th hour.

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-lent-01-02-clean-wednesday-sixth-hour-troparion.pdf>
<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-lent-01-02-clean-wednesday-sixth-hour-troparion.doc>

This Troparion would be an excellent prayer any time of the year. It could be added to the morning rule or evening prayer for that matter; It could be sung or chanted. There are gems like this in all of our services. Read the services and the things that touch your heart; copy them out.

Are we strangers on the earth? Of course, this is a reference to Moses being a Stranger in a strange land when he was in the land of Midian, exiled from his people. During that 40 years in Midian, Moses grew in wisdom and holiness. That time prepared him to be a type of Christ, a savior of his people.

Which kind of stranger are we? Are we a stranger to the world or a stranger to holy things? The Troparion should make us ask this question.

A stranger feels unfamiliar with his surroundings or the people or the things around him. Are we unfamiliar with our surroundings? Or do we know the world all too well? When we are in the services, do we understand them, or do they feel unfamiliar to us? Perhaps they feel too long, or we don't understand specific phrases. Maybe we are not moved to compunction when we hear the words. Maybe the things that are being said and especially the exploits of the saints that are being lauded seem almost unreal to us.

Shouldn't we, with humility, say that we are familiar with the world but strangers to holiness? Of course, in the spiritual life, everything is on a continuum. We are strangers to some sins, and we are familiar

(because of experience) with some holy things. But if we examine ourselves carefully, we would see that we indeed are not strangers to everything evil. We know too much about evil because we have experienced it *internally*. And we know very little about holiness because we have not experienced God internally as those who are holy experience Him.

Wouldn't the beginning of our becoming familiar with God be that we admit to Him that we are strangers to Him in many areas of our life? And wouldn't it also be appropriate for us, as we confess to Him that we are strangers to Him in such things as humility, and chastity, self-control, and unceasing prayer, we would also beg Him with compunction that we would be strangers to at least some things of the world?

And as we beg the Lord to help us be strangers to the world, we must be aware that the enemy that is keeping us from knowing God (and therefore, being strangers to the world) is sin. And we know that we sin. Sin blackens us, and darkens our thoughts, and confuses us. So we should beg the Lord to help keep us without sin.

Of course, just asking this is not a magical incantation. We ask it over and over, and just as often as we ask it, we must act upon our request by struggling against sin, and the grace of God fills us, and eventually, sin is demolished, it is shattered, and it is as far away from us as the East is from the West.